

ticals and financial services are adequately funded with respect to equity. We have Carlyle as an investor in the pharma business and in financial services, cash is the only raw material, which can give you 25-30 per cent growth over the next five years.” In April 2012, Piramal Realty, a Piramal Group company, acquired HUL’s Gulita, a one-acre sea-facing property for ₹452.5 crore, which made way for the sprawling home where we are having this conversation.

When asked what the group will do as part of its continuous change, he jokingly says, “Ask the next generation.” In a moment, he makes it clear that pharmaceuticals and financial services will continue. To him, the group has scale in domestic manufacturing. “There is also an OTC business that we have not spoken much about. On contract manufacturing, the world will continue to outsource and with our four plants in the US, we can offer global solutions, making it a huge strategic advantage,” he says. What cannot be missed is how he mentions pharma as “a scale business”, implying he is ready for that game with the current product portfolio and the M&A route.

Ranjit Shahani, erstwhile Vice Chairman & MD of Novartis India and a former key member of Piramal’s management team, identifies a few attributes that make him stand out. “Ajay Piramal has an uncanny sense of timing honed of course by solid preparatory work done by his team. He has a clear strategic vision for what he wants to achieve and goes for it with missionary and evangelistic zeal,” he says. That apart, Shahani gives credit to Piramal’s negotiating skills to get the optimum value for his shareholders. “Piramal

acquired the domestic businesses of Nicholas, Roche, Boehringer Mannheim, Rhone Poulenc, ICI, Allergan, and HMR, and successfully grew each of them.”

Having seen Piramal from close quarters, Shahani makes another point. “Facts tell but stories sell. Ajay and Swati (Piramal’s wife) work as a close team and have always presented their

proposals in a seductive story format supported by solid numbers and outcomes. This sets them apart from the usual excel sheet presentations of many of the competitive bidders to acquire assets.” To Shahani, Piramal has positioned himself as “a partner of choice” across three decades in addition to developing solid trust with multiple global partners.



PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH

“ We sold two-thirds of the business [to Abbott Laboratories], but that accounted for 95 per cent of the profit. What we had [left] was over 30 per cent of the pharma pie and 5 per cent of the profit

Nandini Piramal
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, PIRAMAL ENTERPRISES